

BALL PYTHON · PYTHON REGIUS

Keep your ball python the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: enclosure, heat and humidity, feeding refusals, health triage, and the routines that carry a snake through 20 to 30 years.

22 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order before buying anything. Enclosure material, heat control, and humidity are the decisions that are expensive to redo, and they are the three that most often get chosen wrong. Get those right the first time, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16 to buy once.

If your snake is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Climate Targets on page 14 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 10 if anything seems off. If the problem is that your snake won't eat, start on page 13 instead, most feeding refusals are normal and the page tells you which ones aren't.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Climate Targets | ☐ Page 19: Daily & Weekly Routine |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 18: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 21: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Ball python husbandry has moved a long way from the small-tub advice that dominated the hobby for years. This package reflects current enclosure-size, humidity, and enrichment standards, including the peer-reviewed housing research on page 9, cross-checked against veterinary and herpetological sources rather than recycled forum advice.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Python regius</i> , also called the royal python
Adult size	3 to 5 ft (90 to 150 cm), 3 to 5 lbs; females noticeably larger
Captive lifespan	20 to 30 years typical, with documented individuals past 40
Native range	Grassland, open forest, and farmland, West and Central Africa
Diet type	Obligate carnivore; appropriately sized frozen-thawed rodents
Enclosure minimum (adult)	4×2×2 ft (≈120 gal), front-opening, PVC preferred
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate; defensive as juveniles, mellow as adults
Conservation status	Least Concern (IUCN); wild populations pressured by collection

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$300 to \$800 for enclosure, thermostat-controlled heat, substrate, hides, and clutter. Up to \$1,200 for premium PVC and a bioactive build.

Monthly ongoing

\$20 to \$60 for frozen-thawed rodents, substrate replacement, and the electricity to run heat continuously.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A sick or emergency visit runs \$100 to \$500 or more, and imaging or surgery pushes that higher. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but a 30-year animal will need a vet at some point. Plan for it now rather than deciding in an emergency.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The name comes from the defensive pose, not the diet. A stressed ball python curls into a tight ball with its head tucked in the center, which is also why a new snake that won't uncurl isn't being difficult, it just hasn't decided yet that hiding is unnecessary.
- They hunt with heat. Pits along the upper lip detect the body warmth of nearby prey, letting a ball python strike accurately in complete darkness.
- Brooding females generate their own heat. Through shivering thermogenesis, a female coiled around her clutch contracts her muscles repeatedly to keep the eggs warmer than the surrounding air.
- More than 7,000 morph combinations have been recorded, making this one of the most genetically varied reptiles in the hobby.

Housing & enclosure

4×2×2 ft (48×24×24 in, roughly 120 gallons, about 8 square feet of floor space) is the adult standard, and the enclosure should be at least as long as the snake. Scale down while the snake is small: hatchlings up to about 300 grams do well in a 10-gallon or 20×11×13 in enclosure, and juveniles under 3 feet in a 36×18×18 in setup. PVC is the better material because it holds humidity far more effectively than glass. If you do use glass, cover three sides to help retain moisture.



Minimum footprint 4 ft (L) × 2 ft (D) × 2 ft (H), at least as long as the snake
Secure, locking, front-opening. Ball pythons are capable escape artists.

NEVER

Run any heat source without a thermostat. An unregulated mat, tape, or panel is the direct cause of thermal burns and is a genuine fire hazard. Skip hot rocks entirely.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Clutter is not decoration for this species. Plants, cork, and leaf litter break up sightlines so the snake can be somewhere other than inside a hide without feeling exposed, which is what prevents the chronic stress that shows up as feeding refusal.
- Size hides snugly. A ball python feels secure when its body contacts the sides at multiple points, not when it is floating in an oversized box.
- House one snake per enclosure. Ball pythons are solitary and there is no husbandry benefit to cohabitation.

Temperature, humidity & lighting

ZONE	TARGET
Warm side surface	88 to 92°F
Air temperature, anywhere in the enclosure	Never above 95°F
Cool side	75 to 80°F
Nighttime	72 to 75°F
Humidity, baseline	55 to 70%
Humidity, during a shed cycle	70 to 80%

Measure the warm side at the surface the snake actually lies on, not the air above it. Use a digital hygrometer rather than a cheap analog dial, which is notoriously inaccurate. If you need supplemental night heat, use a ceramic heat emitter rather than a light, so it doesn't disrupt the photoperiod.

The thermostat is the equipment, not an accessory

Every single heat source runs through a thermostat, no exceptions. An under-tank heater, heat tape, a ceramic emitter, or a radiant panel will all keep climbing without one, and thermal burns are among the most common preventable injuries in this species. Budget for the thermostat as part of the heat source, never as an upgrade to add later.

Humidity is what actually determines success

This is where most ball python problems start. Too dry gives you bad sheds, retained eye caps, and a higher respiratory infection risk. Too wet without ventilation swings the other way toward scale rot. The species needs a stable middle, not a maximum.

What holds humidity steady

A moisture-retaining substrate at 3 to 4 inches deep, a water bowl large enough to soak in, a dedicated humid hide packed with damp sphagnum moss, and light misting when the reading drops. PVC does most of this work for you; glass fights you the whole way.

Lighting and photoperiod

UVB is genuinely optional for this species, kept successfully without it for decades, though a low-level gradient is reasonable enrichment if you want it. What is not optional is a consistent 12 hours light, 12 hours dark cycle on a timer, with no bright or colored bulbs at night.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Shed coming off in pieces rather than one length	Humidity running too low, especially through the shed
Snake soaking in the water bowl constantly	Too dry, too warm, or mites (see page 12)
Condensation on the walls, substrate staying wet	Too humid or too little ventilation, scale rot risk
Sitting on the cool side and refusing to move	Warm side running too hot, check the thermostat probe

Substrate, furnishings & handling

Substrate

Cypress mulch or coconut coir and husk, 3 to 4 inches deep, are the best choices because they hold humidity at the level this species needs. Paper towel works fine temporarily, for quarantine or while treating a health issue, but it won't hold humidity long-term. Avoid aspen entirely, it tends to mold at ball python humidity. Full substrate changes run every 4 to 8 weeks with spot-cleaning in between.

NEVER

Use pine or cedar. Both contain aromatic oils that are toxic to reptiles. This is not a preference, it is a hard exclusion.

Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Two snug hides, one warm side and one cool side
- ☐ Heavy, tip-resistant water bowl the snake can fully enter
- ☐ Sturdy branches braced at both ends, low enough that a fall isn't one
- ☐ Humid hide with damp sphagnum moss, kept year round
- ☐ Cork bark tubes and flats for floor-level cover
- ☐ Leaf litter or plants to break up open sightlines

Handling

Don't handle a newly acquired ball python for the first one to two weeks, and don't start until it is eating on a normal schedule. A snake still adjusting to a new enclosure and without an established feeding rhythm is not ready to be picked up. Once settled, 2 to 3 sessions a week is a reasonable baseline, up to 3 to 5 for a snake that handles well, keeping each session to 15 to 30 minutes. Overhandling causes real stress in this species and is a common cause of feeding refusal, so more is not automatically better.

Approach from the side rather than straight down from above, which reads as predatory. Support the full body with both hands or along your forearms, lifting from the middle rather than near the head or tail, and let the snake move at its own pace instead of restraining it.

THE TWO TIMING RULES THAT ACTUALLY MATTER

Wait 48 to 72 hours after a meal before handling, since handling too soon is one of the most common causes of regurgitation. And don't handle during a shed: cloudy or blue eyes mean the snake is functionally blind for a few days, which makes it more defensive and more likely to bite out of startlement rather than aggression.

Signs to end the session

Balling up tightly with the head tucked away (a fear response, not aggression), rapid or heavy breathing, hiding the head against your hand or arm, actively trying to move away, musking, or refusing the next meal. Musking, a foul-smelling release from the cloaca, means the snake feels seriously threatened. Put it back.

Diet & feeding by age

Ball pythons are obligate carnivores fed whole prey. Unlike most pets, the schedule gets slower as the animal gets bigger, not faster.

AGE	FREQUENCY	TYPICAL PREY
Hatchling (0 to 6 mo)	Every 5 to 7 days	Hopper or small mouse, matched to body width
Juvenile (6 to 18 mo)	Every 7 to 10 days	Adult mouse to small rat
Adult (18 mo+)	Every 10 to 14 days	Medium rat

Prey size

Feed prey roughly the same width as the widest part of the snake's body, or about 10% of its weight. Too large risks regurgitation, too small provides inadequate nutrition over time. Resist the urge to overfeed on the theory that a bigger snake is a healthier one. Obesity is real and common in captive ball pythons, and a slow feeding schedule is a feature of the species, not a problem to solve.

Thawing, done correctly

Seal the frozen rodent in a bag and submerge it in warm, not hot, water until it is warm all the way through, usually 15 to 20 minutes for a medium rat. Never microwave prey: it heats unevenly, leaving hot spots that can burn a snake's mouth while the center stays frozen.

Where to feed

In the enclosure, with tongs. Moving a ball python to a separate feeding tub was once standard advice, but the added stress is now understood to raise both regurgitation and refusal rates in an already food-shy species.

NEVER FEED

Live prey. A live rodent can bite and seriously injure a snake, sometimes fatally, especially one that isn't hungry enough to strike immediately. Frozen-thawed removes that risk entirely and is the standard veterinary recommendation. Also avoid prey wider than the snake's thickest point, and don't handle your snake right after handling rodents.

Water

A heavy bowl large enough for the snake to soak in, refreshed daily and scrubbed weekly. Soaking supports shedding and hydration and is a behavior the snake will choose for itself when the option exists. A snake that suddenly soaks constantly is telling you something about heat, humidity, or mites, covered on pages 6 and 12.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Running a heat source without a thermostat, the single most common cause of a preventable injury in this species.
- Treating the small tub as the goal rather than the compromise, then never moving the snake into a real enclosure.
- Guessing at humidity, or trusting an analog dial, instead of reading a digital hygrometer.
- Panicking at a refused meal and responding by handling, moving, or offering food more often, all of which make refusal more likely.
- Handling within 48 hours of a meal, then treating the resulting regurgitation as bad luck.
- Leaving the enclosure bare because clutter looks untidy, in an animal whose stress response is driven by feeling exposed.
- Skipping quarantine for a new snake or for decor that has touched another reptile.

THE ENRICHMENT QUESTION HAS AN ACTUAL ANSWER

Kaufmann and colleagues, in *PLOS ONE*, compared 35 ball pythons in a conventional rack system against furnished terrariums containing substrate, hides, climbing structure, a water basin large enough to bathe in, elevated spots, and live plants. Their conclusion was unusually direct: from a welfare standpoint, rack systems are not an alternative to a furnished terrarium. Enrichment for this species is mostly a housing question, not a toy question.

Enrichment, by priority

1. A furnished enclosure

The part with a study behind it. The whole furnished package outperformed the bare one, so treat the enclosure itself as the enrichment rather than something you add items to.

3. Stable climbing structure

They are heavy-bodied and not agile, so the requirement is stability, not height. A branch braced firmly at both ends, or stacked cork rounds, adds usable space to an enclosure that otherwise has only a floor.

5. Scent novelty

Snakes navigate chemically, so a novel scent is closer to a puzzle than a novel object is. A shed skin from another enclosure, or dragging prey across the substrate before offering it, costs nothing.

2. Cover across the whole floor

Not just two hides. Cork tubes and flats, leaf litter, and plant cover let the snake be out without being exposed. A cluttered enclosure gets used more, not less.

4. A basin large enough to soak in

The study's terrariums included a bathing basin, not a drinking cup. It is one of the few genuinely passive enrichment items: you provide it, the animal decides.

6. Rearrangement, genuinely last

Shifting a branch or adding a piece of cork every few weeks is reasonable. Tearing the enclosure down weekly is not, and never at the cost of access to the warm spot.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Wheezing, open-mouth breathing, or mucus and bubbles around the mouth or nostrils; belly scales that are discolored, blistered, or spreading; pinpoint hemorrhages, pus, or a sour smell in the mouth; a prolapse; visible mites; or refusal to eat alongside real weight loss.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Current warm side and cool side temperatures, and whether they run through a thermostat
- ☐ Date and quality of the last shed, including any retained eye caps
- ☐ Current humidity reading and what you measured it with
- ☐ Weight trend over the last several entries in your log
- ☐ Date of the last meal, and whether it was kept down
- ☐ Substrate type and when it was last fully changed

Why temperature and humidity come up first

Almost everything in this section traces back to one of the two. Respiratory infection, scale rot, stuck shed, and a large share of feeding refusals are husbandry outcomes before they are illnesses, which is why a reptile vet will ask about your setup before anything else. Having the numbers ready shortens the visit and often changes the diagnosis.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Refusing a meal or two in a snake in good body condition, especially in winter or breeding season	Refusal alongside weight loss, lethargy, or any other symptom on this page
Balling up when startled, then relaxing once left alone	Staying balled and hidden constantly, with no interest in moving at night
Cloudy or blue eyes and dull color for a few days before a shed	Shed coming off in fragments, or eye caps still attached afterward
Soaking in the water bowl occasionally, most often around a shed	Soaking constantly, or rubbing against surfaces persistently

Respiratory infection & scale rot

Respiratory infection (RI)

Cause: temperatures running too low, incorrect humidity in either direction, a dirty enclosure, or ongoing stress. Vets see a seasonal spike each winter as enclosures cool along with the weather outside. **Signs:** wheezing, open-mouth breathing, visible mucus or bubbles around the mouth or nostrils, nasal discharge, lethargy, and sometimes gaping. **Diagnosis:** physical exam and listening to the lungs, with the vet asking about your temperature setup directly. **Response:** vet-prescribed antibiotics, not a wait-and-see approach. Correct the temperature and humidity in parallel or it recurs. **Recovery:** good when caught early; left untreated it can progress to pneumonia and become fatal.

THIS IS THE SIGNATURE BALL PYTHON ILLNESS

If you learn to recognize one condition in this package by sight and sound, make it this one. Raise the enclosure temperature, check humidity immediately, isolate the snake if you keep others, and get to a vet.

Scale rot (infectious dermatitis)

Cause: damp, dirty substrate, excess moisture, or poor enclosure hygiene, which is the exact failure mode of chasing humidity numbers without ventilation. **Signs:** belly scales discolored brown, reddish, or yellow, blisters or sores, scales that feel soft or damaged, and a foul odor. **Diagnosis:** visual exam; a vet may culture if it is advanced. **Response:** move the snake to a clean, dry enclosure immediately and correct humidity. Mild cases respond to antiseptic or antibiotic treatment, but anything spreading or blistering needs a vet. **Recovery:** affected scales usually resolve over the next one to two shed cycles once the environment is fixed.

THE COMMON THREAD

Both conditions are humidity failures in opposite directions. Respiratory infection follows cold and damp or cold and dry; scale rot follows wet substrate that never dries out. A stable 55 to 70% with real ventilation prevents both, which is why page 6 is the highest-leverage page in this package.

Mouth rot, mites & thermal burns

Three conditions worth knowing by name before you ever see them.

Mouth rot (infectious stomatitis)

Cause: usually secondary to stress, injury, or ongoing poor husbandry rather than arriving on its own. **Signs:** pinpoint hemorrhages on the gums, thick excess mucus or pus, cheesy-looking buildup in the mouth, a sour smell, visible swelling, open-mouth breathing, and refusing food. **Response:** veterinary treatment. This does not resolve on its own, and because it often rides on top of another husbandry problem, the vet visit should come with an honest account of your setup.

Mites

Cause: almost always introduced, on a new snake, on used decor, or from a shop or expo. **Signs:** tiny red or black specks on the scales or clustered around the eyes and heat pits, excessive soaking, rubbing against enclosure surfaces, and a drop in appetite. **Response:** treating the snake and deep-cleaning the entire enclosure, since mites persist in the environment after the snake looks clear. Expect to strip substrate completely and treat again on a schedule your vet sets.

QUARANTINE IS THE ACTUAL FIX

Mites are the reason quarantine exists. Keep a new snake fully separate, on paper towel in a simple setup, with separate tools and hand-washing between enclosures, for long enough to be confident it is clean before it goes anywhere near an established animal.

Thermal burns

Cause: a heat source running without a thermostat. That is the entire cause. **Signs:** discolored, blistered, or crusted patches on the belly or side, usually over the heat element, sometimes with the snake avoiding the warm side entirely. **Response:** vet visit; burns are wounds and can become infected. **Prevention:** every heat element thermostat-controlled, no hot rocks, and a probe placed where the snake actually contacts the heat.

THE COMMON THREAD

One of these three is fully preventable by a single piece of equipment, one by a quarantine habit, and one by not letting the other problems on this page run untreated. None of them are bad luck.

Stuck shed, feeding refusal & regurgitation

Stuck shed (dysecdysis)

Caused by humidity running too low, especially through the shed cycle itself. A healthy shed comes off in one length; a bad one comes off in flakes and patches. Raise humidity to 70 to 80% once the eyes go cloudy, make sure the humid hide is genuinely damp, and give the snake a rough surface such as cork to start the shed against. Never peel skin off by force. After every shed, check the eye caps: a retained cap is one of the easiest problems to miss because the snake's behavior looks completely normal, and it needs a vet rather than a home attempt.

Feeding refusal

Ball pythons are famous for this, and a healthy snake in good body condition refusing a meal or two is not an emergency. Work through the causes in order before assuming illness.

- **Breeding season, roughly October through March.** Males especially go off food, and this is completely normal.
- **Shedding.** Most snakes refuse while in shed, signaled by opaque eyes and dull skin.
- **Temperature or humidity out of range.** The most common husbandry cause, and the first thing to check.
- **Stress.** A new enclosure, too much handling, or too little cover.
- **Seasonal slowdown.** A milder version of what wild ball pythons do through West Africa's cooler, drier months.

A healthy adult can go three to six months without eating and lose surprisingly little condition. What turns a fast into a problem is company: rapid weight loss, lethargy, mucus around the mouth, or wheezing alongside the refusal.

Regurgitation

Bringing a meal back up hours to days after eating, most often from handling too soon after a feed, prey that was too large, or a warm side that is too cool to digest properly. It is hard on the digestive system and repeated episodes cause real damage. After one, leave the snake alone for 10 to 14 days, then offer a smaller than usual prey item. Repeated regurgitation is a vet visit, not a feeding adjustment.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

A refused meal is a snake that never struck. A regurgitation is a meal that was eaten and came back. The first is usually normal and needs patience; the second means something in the setup or the handling schedule is wrong, and it needs to be found before the next feed.

Setup checklist & climate targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 4×2×2 ft enclosure, secure, locking, front-opening
- ☐ Heat source sized to the enclosure
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer, not analog dials
- ☐ Two snug hides, warm side and cool side
- ☐ Heavy water bowl large enough to soak in
- ☐ Timer for a 12 hour light, 12 hour dark cycle
- ☐ PVC preferred; glass covered on three sides
- ☐ Thermostat, one per heat source, no exceptions
- ☐ Cypress mulch or coconut coir, 3 to 4 in deep
- ☐ Humid hide with sphagnum moss
- ☐ Cork, branches, and leaf litter for cover
- ☐ Frozen-thawed rodent supply and feeding tongs

Climate targets

TARGET	RANGE
Warm side surface	88 to 92°F
Air temperature ceiling, anywhere	95°F
Cool side	75 to 80°F
Nighttime	72 to 75°F
Humidity, baseline	55 to 70%
Humidity, through a shed	70 to 80%
Photoperiod	12 hours light / 12 hours dark

Before your snake comes home

- ☐ Enclosure fully set up and running for 24 to 48 hours first
- ☐ Warm and cool side confirmed with a thermometer, not by feel
- ☐ Frozen-thawed prey in the freezer before day one
- ☐ Thermostat probe placed where the snake will actually contact heat
- ☐ Humidity holding in range for a full day without intervention
- ☐ Reptile-experienced vet identified and their hours noted

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

Wheezing, open-mouth breathing, or bubbles at the mouth or nose · belly scales blistering or discoloration spreading · pus, hemorrhages, or a sour smell in the mouth · a prolapse · visible mites · a burn over the heat source · refusal to eat alongside real weight loss

READING	TARGET
Warm side surface	88 to 92°F
Air ceiling, anywhere	Never above 95°F
Cool side	75 to 80°F
Nighttime low	72 to 75°F
Humidity, baseline	55 to 70%
Humidity, during shed	70 to 80%
Feeding interval, adult	Every 10 to 14 days
Wait after feeding before handling	48 to 72 hours

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Warm and cool side temperatures, current humidity, whether heat runs on a thermostat, the date of the last meal and whether it stayed down, the date and quality of the last shed, and the weight trend from your Owner Log.

BEFORE YOU PANIC ABOUT A REFUSED MEAL

Check the season, check the eyes for a coming shed, then check temperature and humidity. A healthy snake in good condition that refuses one or two meals with none of the red flags above is doing something normal for the species.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
The snake (standard or wild-type)	\$40 to \$100
Common single-gene morph, if you go that way	\$50 to \$150
Enclosure, 4×2×2 ft for an adult	\$100 to \$450
Heat source (mat, tape, ceramic emitter, or panel)	\$30 to \$80
Thermostat	\$25 to \$100
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$25 to \$50
Substrate (cypress mulch or coconut coir)	\$10 to \$40
Hides, water bowl, cork, and clutter	\$30 to \$120
Optional low-level UVB and photoperiod LED	\$20 to \$70
Initial vet exam	\$50 to \$150
Total initial setup	\$300 to \$800
Frozen-thawed rodents (annual)	\$100 to \$200
Substrate replacement, every 4 to 8 weeks (annual)	\$40 to \$120
Electricity, heat running continuously (annual)	\$20 to \$80
Monthly ongoing	\$20 to \$60

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Sick or emergency visits run \$100 to \$500 or more, with imaging or surgery pushing higher. Budget \$50 to \$150 for an annual wellness exam. A small emergency fund matters as much as any line item on this list, especially for an animal you will keep for decades.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The thermostat and the enclosure. The thermostat is the difference between a heat source and a burn, and the enclosure size and material drive the humidity stability that most of Section 03 depends on. Save on decor and extras before you save here.

THE LONG VIEW

Spread \$300 to \$800 of setup across a 20 to 30 year lifespan and the ball python has one of the lowest per-year costs of any exotic pet. The expensive year is the first one.

First 30 days checklist

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm warm side, cool side, and humidity with real instruments, not "feels warm"
- ☐ Hands off entirely: no handling, only spot-cleaning and fresh water
- ☐ Offer the first meal at the end of the week, at the size and prey type the seller was using
- ☐ Note the seller's feeding schedule, last meal date, and last shed date in your log

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin short handling sessions only once your snake has eaten on schedule at least once
- ☐ Keep sessions to 15 minutes, and never within 48 to 72 hours of a meal
- ☐ Schedule a wellness vet visit with a reptile-experienced vet
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 20, including weight

Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend. Steady is the goal, gradual gain for a juvenile
- ☐ Confirm the humid hide is still genuinely damp and top up the moss
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 21, one at a time
- ☐ Do the first full substrate change and enclosure clean

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Watch the first shed closely and log its quality, including eye caps
- ☐ Settle into the age-appropriate feeding interval from page 8
- ☐ Look back at the log for slow drift in weight, humidity, or temperature rather than single readings
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 21

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Wheezing, open-mouth breathing, bubbles at the mouth	Respiratory infection	Vet immediately (page 11)
Belly scales discolored, soft, or blistered	Scale rot	Dry, clean setup now; vet if spreading (page 11)
Pus, sour smell, or hemorrhages in the mouth	Mouth rot	Vet, does not self-resolve (page 12)
Tiny black or red specks, constant soaking	Mites	Vet + full enclosure strip (page 12)
Burn or blister over the heat source	Unregulated heat	Vet; add a thermostat before anything else (page 12)
Shed coming off in patches	Humidity too low	Raise to 70 to 80%, check eye caps (page 13)
Refusing food, otherwise normal and in good condition	Season, shed, or husbandry	Check temps and humidity, then wait (page 13)
Refusing food with weight loss or lethargy	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 20)
Meal brought back up after eating	Regurgitation	Rest 10 to 14 days, then smaller prey (page 13)
Out and roaming persistently, never settling	Too little cover, or too warm	Add clutter, verify temps (pages 5 and 6)
Musking or striking during handling	Stress or a feeding response	End the session, review timing (page 7)

Daily & weekly routine

Daily

- ☐ Check warm side, cool side, and humidity readings
- ☐ Refresh the water bowl
- ☐ Spot-clean any waste
- ☐ Quick visual check: eyes, mouth, belly scales, posture, breathing

Weekly

- ☐ Feed per the age-based interval on page 8, and log it
- ☐ Weigh and log, ideally on the same day each week
- ☐ Scrub the water bowl rather than just topping it up
- ☐ Check the humid hide is still damp and refresh the moss
- ☐ Rotate or refresh one enrichment item

Monthly

- ☐ Full substrate change and enclosure deep clean, every 4 to 8 weeks
- ☐ Verify the thermostat is holding its set point and the probe hasn't shifted
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends rather than single readings
- ☐ Check that hides still fit snugly as the snake grows

Seasonal

- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings between summer and winter, the winter drop is when respiratory infections spike
- ☐ Expect reduced appetite through breeding season, roughly October to March
- ☐ Check that dry indoor heating hasn't pulled humidity below range

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	WARM °F	COOL °F	HUMIDITY	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

In a species that normally refuses meals, the weight trend is the only thing that tells you whether a fast is routine or a symptom. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a weight change before anything else is visible.

Feeding & shed log

DATE	PREY / EVENT	OUTCOME

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ Cover across the whole floor, not only inside the two hides
- ☐ Stable climbing structure braced at both ends, low enough that a fall isn't one
- ☐ Water basin large enough for the snake to fully enter
- ☐ Two snug hides at different temperatures, plus a humid hide
- ☐ Leaf litter or plants breaking up open sightlines

Monthly review

- ☐ Add or reposition one piece of cover, without blocking access to the warm spot
- ☐ Offer a scent novelty: a shed skin from another enclosure, or prey dragged across the substrate before offering
- ☐ Reassess whether hides and branches still fit the snake's current size
- ☐ Confirm the snake is using more of the floor than it did last month, not less

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't treat handling as enrichment, especially around a shed cycle. Don't stack decor so densely that the snake can't reach the warm spot, thermal access outranks everything here. And don't read a still, hidden snake in a bare enclosure as a calm one, that is the pattern the rack comparison produced.

Enrichment log

DATE	CHANGE MADE	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Dysecdysis	Incomplete or "stuck" shedding, in this species usually a whole-body problem caused by low humidity rather than a localized one.
Eye cap	The clear scale covering the eye, shed with the rest of the skin. A retained cap is easy to miss and needs a vet.
F/T	Frozen-thawed prey, the standard and safer alternative to live feeding.
Humid hide	A closed hide packed with damp sphagnum moss, giving the snake a high-humidity pocket it can choose to use.
Musking	A foul-smelling release from the cloaca, a clear signal the snake feels threatened.
Regurgitation	Bringing a meal back up after swallowing, most often from handling too soon, oversized prey, or insufficient warmth.
Scale rot	Infectious dermatitis of the belly scales, driven by damp, dirty substrate.
Stomatitis	Mouth rot: bacterial infection of the mouth, usually secondary to stress or poor husbandry.
Thermostat	The device that regulates a heat source to a set temperature. Not optional, and not the same thing as a dimmer or a timer.
Quarantine	Keeping a new or unwell snake fully separate from others, including separate tools and hand-washing between handling, to prevent disease and mite spread.

Compiled from veterinary and herpetological sources, including the peer-reviewed ball python housing research cited on page 9, and cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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